cent of the electorate—and also enjoys considerable goodwill among women. As a result, whichever side Nitish is on, victory is usually assured for that coalition.

So, the NDA is fighting with Nitish as its tutelar deity, repurposing for 2025 the old contrast between his '*sushasan*' (good governance) and Lalu's 'Jungle Raj'. But the BJP is not unaware that the Nitish of today is also a liability. That's why it has stopped short of naming him as its chief ministerial candidate. In this reading, the persona of Nitish is not unlike that of a vehicle—a Trojan horse, if you will. To instil the sense of a coalition rather than a singularity, the NDA holds out the promise of '*pragati*' (progress) under a 'double-engine sarkar', with the larger-than-life Modi factor a vital ingredient of it. Complementing this will be the RSS-BJP's organisational sinew—disciplined booth committees, micro-targeting through social networks, financial muscle and a calibrated caste outreach.

There is also Chirag Paswan. No bit player, the Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) chief returns to the NDA fold with a modest but crucial 5 per cent Paswan vote. His presence should bolster the alliance's prospects, particularly those of the JD(U). For, the LJP's 10.26 per cent vote share in the 135 seats contested on its own in the 2020 Bihar election had come chiefly at the cost of the JD(U). When Chirag fought the 2024 general election as part of the NDA, the effect was at once visible—the JD(U) led in 74 assembly segments, up from its dismal tally of 43 in 2020.

Leadership Woes

Nitish thus still flies on the flag of the NDA's come-what-may constant, and commands loyalty among the older voters. But the generational churn is visible. For the 17 million-strong youth voters aged 18-29 in Bihar, the 74-year-old may no longer be the face of aspiration. Concerns over his visibly frail health also lend a quiet undertone of uncertainty. This election, therefore, will be a verdict on Nitish—victory will keep him in play; defeat would trigger a succession drama.

The BJP's state leadership—deputy chief ministers Samrat Choudhary and Vijay Kumar Sinha, alongside new state president Dilip Jaiswal—provides the organisational scaffolding, but just that. They lack the sort of gravitas that has pan-Bihar appeal, not unlike the JD(U) second-rung figures Sanjay Kumar Jha and Rajiv Ranjan Singh. And while Chirag may have demonstrated chief ministerial ambition, he faces a practical constraint: with no MLAs in the current assembly, whatever prospects he has hinge on post-poll permutations rather than self-propulsion. As part of NDA, he is likely to get a far lesser share of seats than the grand foray of 135 he managed as an independent in 2020. The influence he will wield post-counting too will be proportionately scaled.



PTI

Chirag has the Paswan vote tied up, but the rest of the Dalit vote will see fragmentation; Congress is eyeing the 5.3% Ravidas vote with the help of new state chief Rajesh Kumar